

Mayor, LAPD tout data on drop in crimes

Anti-violence efforts led to a 14% decline in homicides and 225 fewer gunfire victims last year, they say.

By LIBOR JANY

Los Angeles leaders are touting the latest batch of crime data as proof that the city is safe and getting safer — at least on paper.

Homicides declined roughly 14% in the city last year compared with 2023, while 225 fewer people were struck by gunfire citywide in the same period, according to figures released Monday.

The total number of homicides fell by 47 in areas patrolled by the L.A. Police Department, with the San Fernando Valley seeing the largest percentage decrease of the department's four geographical bureaus, with a 28% decline in slayings last year from 2023.

City and police officials attributed the declines to programs aimed at some of the city's historically troubled housing developments. Areas where the LAPD's Community Safety Partnership and the mayor's gang intervention office "have taken proactive measures to engage residents" saw a 40% reduction in homicides, the city said in a statement.

Mayor Karen Bass and LAPD Chief Jim McDonnell held a news conference Monday morning to trumpet the anti-violence initiatives.

"This progress is the direct result of the tireless work of our law enforcement officers, community leaders and residents who have come together to build a safer, stronger city," Bass said in a statement. "While we recognize this progress, we remain committed to sustaining these reductions and ensuring that every resident feels safe in their home, on their street and in their community."

McDonnell called the dwindling homicide and shooting numbers a reflection of "the impact of our ongoing commitment to public safety and the strength of

[See Crimes, A5]



Photographs by JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

ELIOT ARTS Magnet Academy was among the schools burned in the Eaton fire. Pasadena Unified has suffered years of declining enrollment and is grappling with the exhaustion of pandemic-era U.S. funds.

Already reeling from fire, Pasadena Unified cuts staff

Many districts are seeing layoffs, but the pain is especially acute as teachers and students face Eaton blaze aftermath

By Daniel Miller



JOY McCREARY, a teacher at Blair Middle and High School in Pasadena who is seven months pregnant, recently got a layoff notice.

Joy McCreary's 12th-grade advanced literature class had just ended at Blair Middle and High School when a substitute teacher came to relieve her. McCreary was needed in the principal's office. She sensed what was coming.

Pasadena Unified School District, rolled by years of declining enrollment and grappling with the exhaustion of pandemic-era federal funds, needed to slash \$12 million from its budget — and the school board had just voted to send out preliminary layoff notices to dozen of teachers. McCreary, who is seven months pregnant, did a simple calculation: "The golden rule is last in, first out. The writing was on the wall. I can do the math, I can count the positions."

McCreary, 28, began gathering her things. Students noticed. "They asked, 'What's going on?' And I said, 'I'm probably about to be laid off right now,'" she told The Times. "And they asked, 'What are you talking about? ... This is crazy.'"

Then they pleaded with her, "You can't leave us."

Pasadena Unified isn't alone: Nearly 2,000 teachers in about 40 California school districts have received preliminary layoff notices in recent weeks, according to the California Teachers Assn. Districts

[See Pasadena, A5]

Wider areas may be at risk of tsunami

A worst-case scenario could bring flooding to swaths of Marina del Rey, Long Beach and farther inland.

By RONG-GONG LIN II AND GRACE TOOHEY

The risk of damaging flooding from a major tsunami may be greater than many realized along stretches of California's renowned coastline, state officials say, further reinforcing the need for residents to take note if they live in or visit hazardous areas.

The most recent risk assessment, outlined in maps that were published by the California Geological Survey and reviewed by The Times, illustrates the devastation that could result from scenarios considered to be extreme but realistic. For instance, a large tsunami could flood swaths of Marina del Rey, Long Beach and the nearby dual port complex to an elevation of up to 15 feet above sea level.

A worst-case tsunami could bring flooding to sizable areas of Oakland, Berkeley and Alameda, up to 18 feet above sea level.

Flooding could reach up to 30 feet above the average high tide along the outer coast of Humboldt Bay and the Eureka area, and up to 50 feet toward Crescent City and Cayucos.

[See Tsunami, A10]

State bill would protect wetlands

Proposal aims to restore safeguards after Supreme Court ruling limited them.

By IAN JAMES

California lawmakers are proposing legislation that aims to reestablish safeguards for the state's streams and wetlands in response to a Supreme Court ruling limiting federal clean water regulations.

Supporters say the legislation has taken on heightened urgency as the Trump administration begins to scale back protections for many streams and wetlands, making them vulnerable to pollution and worsening water quality.

"We need clean water to drink, to grow our food, to support healthy ecosystems and the environment," said state Sen. Ben Allen (D-Santa Monica), who introduced the bill. "It's about protecting our water supply, and it's a common-sense measure that simply restores the protections that our waterways have always enjoyed since 1948."

Federal standards have since 1948 limited pollution discharges into waterways.

[See Wetlands, A7]

Schiff rejects Trump's 'void' claim about Biden pardons

Senator says assertion regarding the Jan. 6 committee members is 'baseless,' and they will not be silenced.

By KEVIN RECTOR

Sen. Adam Schiff on Monday rebuffed as a baseless threat a weekend broadside from President Trump in which Trump alleged that Schiff and others could still face investigation for actions covered by a slate of late pardons issued by President Biden.

"Your threats will not intimidate us," the California Democrat wrote on X. "Or silence us."

Schiff, elected last year to fill the Senate seat long held by the late Sen. Dianne Feinstein, is among those who received a pardon from Biden

in the final days of his presidency, despite having personally discouraged the move.

Schiff previously served in the House, where he helped lead the select committee to investigate the Jan. 6, 2021, attack on the U.S. Capitol by Trump's supporters. The committee's work led to Trump being impeached by the House — for a second time — for inciting the insurrection, which was an attempt to block the transfer of power to Biden.

Before leaving office, Biden issued a burst of pardons that he said were designed to protect individuals who had done nothing wrong but who could nonetheless be targeted for retribution by Trump. That included the members of the select committee, including Schiff, one of Trump's most vociferous critics.

Trump has lambasted Biden's pardons since they were issued. But he went a step further in a Sunday post on his social media website, in which he adopted a conspiracy theory pushed online by right-wing pundits that Biden's pardons were invalid because they were signed using an "autopen" — resulting in a digital, not handwritten, signature.

The theory ignores the fact that digital signatures are commonly used across government and have been accepted for years, that other presidents have used autopens to sign important measures and pardons, and that the Justice Department's Office of Legal Counsel under President George W. Bush issued a memorandum opinion justifying their use in 2005.

The theory also plays on the notion that Biden, now

[See Pardons, A5]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

PLAY BALL!

Crews prepare the Tokyo Dome for the Dodgers' season opener against the Chicago Cubs at 3 a.m. PDT. See game coverage at latimes.com.

Rain heads out of town, for now

Sunshine is set to return after a wet week that's done little to offset a dry winter.

CALIFORNIA, B1

Weather

Sunny and warmer. L.A. Basin: 71/47. **B5**

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'Joker' producer files for Chap. 11

Village Roadshow blames a battle with Warner over "Matrix" sequel. **BUSINESS, A6**

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